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CROATIA STRATEGY

The brinksmanship of Zagreb's announcement ending UNPROFOR's mission could break the logjam that has kept a Serbo-Croat settlement out of reach, but it could also trigger hostilities with human and diplomatic casualties. The U.S. approach to Croatia must be three-pronged: maintain the essential functions of UNPROFOR in Croatia; launch a negotiating process between Serbs and Croats on a political settlement; and prepare to respond to renewed hostilities. In public, we should not undercut Croatia. But as we receive strategic warning of renewed hostilities, we must make clear to Tudjman that key elements of our bilateral relationship will be at risk. (✓)

U.S. must show support for Croatian goals . . .

In the ten weeks before UNPROFOR's current mandate expires, the U.S. will have to strike a balance, supporting Zagreb's ends while opposing its most dangerous means. There can be no question that we endorse restoration of Croatian sovereignty over the Serb-held areas, or that we recognize Croatia's role as a bulwark against Serb aggression. The U.S. has a strategic interest in backing Croatia as long as Zagreb continues to support the Federation, i.e. to keep the Bosnian Croats from cutting a deal with the Serbs to carve up Bosnia. In addition, strong bilateral cooperation will help keep Zagreb on the path of Western political and economic reform.

. . . while minimizing risks of war

We must nevertheless minimize the dangers in Tudjman's high-risk strategy for pressuring the Serbs. His approach makes a renewed conflagration more likely, particularly if UNPROFOR's withdrawal leaves the separation zone between the Croat and Serb armies unsupervised. While Tudjman's intention to avoid war seems genuine, he seems more prepared to contemplate it than ever before. If fighting breaks out, he claims that: (1) Croatia can make significant military gains against the Krajina Serbs; (2) Serbia proper will stay out (at least if Croatia spares Sector East). Both propositions are doubtful, and they cancel each other out: the more territory Croatia regains, the less likely Serbia is to sit idly by.

Whether started deliberately or accidentally, renewed Serbo-Croat warfare would have many casualties. First, the Bosnia cease-fire would unravel. Bosnian Serbs would probably attack Croatian Army forces in Bosnia (who are prepositioned to attack the Krajina Serb capital from the east). In addition,

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2014-0311-M (1.01)
2/27/2017 KBH

GOBH forces would be tempted to strike when Krajina Serbs are tied down in Croatia and unable to assist their Bosnian brethren as they did in Bihac. Second, an attack on Serbs in Croatia would rally Serb nationalists, pressuring Milosevic to re-open the border with Bosnia to resupply the Krajina Serbs. Third, substantial human casualties would result, particularly among civilians in Croatian towns, which have usually been subject to Krajina Serb shelling when hostilities erupt. Fourth, the conflict would undermine Bosnian relief efforts, which are staged from Croatia to a large extent.

UNPROFOR Negotiations

In stressing that his decision to expel UNPROFOR is irrevocable, Tudjman has made it almost inevitable that UNPROFOR as we know it has no future after March. But he has left the door open to preserving the elements that the U.S. has defined as essential. These are: cease-fire monitoring in Croatia; liaison with Knin; confidence-building measures implementation; support for Bosnia operations; force headquarters. They do not require the substantial troop presence throughout the UNPAs that UNPROFOR now maintains.

Zagreb has indicated it would accept continued UNPROFOR operations on Croatia soil in support of Bosnia, as well as an international presence to pursue the Croatia-related tasks. These tasks could be fulfilled by a UN mission with a different name. It would report to the UNSYG through Akashi in order to remain integrated with UNPROFOR, similar to the organization of the various UN peacekeeping operations in the Middle East.

The mission's top priority would be monitoring the separation zones established by the March '94 cease-fire. Otherwise, the vacuum left by UNPROFOR's withdrawal would draw Serb and Croat forces into clashes. This return to the pre-cease-fire situation is more dangerous now because both sides are spoiling for a fight; isolated incidents would quickly escalate into full-scale confrontation. International monitors could act as a brake by providing an early-warning system. Since they would not be deployed to deter a military offensive -- neither is UNPROFOR at present -- they could be unarmed. Similarly, liaison with Knin and implementation of confidence-building measures, except for de-mining, are not tasks requiring military skills.

UNSC negotiations on a new mandate are unlikely to begin until the March 31 expiration approaches. In developing a new mandate for the UN presence in Croatia, Zagreb will wait to

show flexibility in order to maintain maximum pressure on the Serbs. At the appropriate time, the U.S. should mediate between the Croats on the one hand and the UNSYG's representatives and key UNSC members on the other. No other country is positioned to do so. To prepare, we should use the intervening weeks to explore the nuts and bolts of desired UN activity in Croatia with the responsible UN officials, especially incoming force commander Smith.

Update on Launching Negotiations via the Z-4

The Z-4 Mediators (the Zagreb Ambassadors of the U.S., Russia, EU, and UN) have now finalized all provisions of their constitutional plan and map for a Croatia settlement. Their proposal to grant autonomy to ethnic Serb areas while restoring Croatian sovereignty throughout its territory is a framework for accomplishing the urgent task of bringing the parties to the negotiating table. The Z-4 are scheduled to present the plan in Zagreb and Knin on January 30 and in Belgrade on January 31. They will meet subsequently with the parties to explain the provisions and present the map, and then to organize negotiations.

We should emphasize that negotiations on a settlement must start soon and that we expect the parties to consider the Z-4 Plan seriously, since it represents what the international community is prepared to support. With the backing of all the major powers, we would expect a final settlement to look very much like this proposal, but it is not a take-it-or-leave-it proposition.

While Bosnia negotiations have gone on in one form or another for several years, a political settlement in Croatia has never been the subject of serious talks among the parties. Little has occurred in recent years to induce them to negotiate. It may be months or years until they are ready to settle, and additional fighting may occur. It is doubtful, moreover, that the fractured Krajina Serb leadership will pursue talks with Zagreb unless Belgrade dispels the dream of Greater Serbia, e.g. with recognition of Croatia and its international borders.

Despite the odds, however, every attempt must be made to launch negotiations. The bargaining would take place between representatives of Zagreb and Knin. Belgrade need not be represented if it endorses the basic plan and makes the Krajina Serbs attend. We can be flexible on modalities and venues, with the organizing principle being to support whatever works. At some point, we will have to consider possible incentives and

disincentives to keep the negotiations going, but doing so now would be premature. The bottom line is that unless we find a way to get the parties to confront each other at the negotiating table, they will move closer to a face-off on the battlefield.

Preparing for the worst

While making every effort to preserve an UNPROFOR presence that can deter renewed conflict and to invigorate the diplomatic track, the U.S. must also consider what to do in the event that hostilities erupt as a result of apparent Croatian recklessness. Senior U.S. officials (Albright, Tarnoff, Slocombe, Holbrooke, Galbraith) have already delivered the two-part message to the Croats: we will work with you to restore Croatian sovereignty, but we will not understand or help if you provoke a war. We have to keep reinforcing this message.

For now, it makes sense to hold off on intensifying military cooperation until the UNPROFOR mandate question is satisfactorily resolved, as U/S Slocombe discussed with President Tudjman on Monday. If a satisfactory new mandate proves impossible or Croatia otherwise demonstrates belligerent intentions, we would scale back the bilateral relationship. These decision would have to be carefully calibrated to respond to the specific circumstances. It nevertheless makes sense to warn the Croats ahead of time that we cannot continue close cooperation if they pursue military confrontation, at least until the possibilities for settlement talks have been exhausted.

We should also work with the UN, NATO, and NGOs to allow essential relief operations in Bosnia to continue with minimal disruption in the event that Croatia becomes unavailable as a staging ground.

Clinton Presidential Records Mandatory Declassification Review

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